HISTART 394-008 Fall 2026

Space and Power

Tuesdays and Thursdays 2:30pm - 4pm

Room 170, Tappan Hall

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Office Hours: Times indicated via wejoinin and by appointment via email.
Room 170E, Tappan Hall.



Illustrator: Howard Barry. Source: https://rethinkingschools.org/articles/simulating-redlining-when-race-was-the-real-currency/

Course Description:
This course asks you to rethink how the world is made—through space. We study how racialized power is built into landscapes, neighborhoods, borders, and infrastructures, and how everyday practices of dwelling, movement, and protest assemble counter-spaces and alternative geographies of justice. Rather than treating places as closed containers, we approach them as relational formations shaped by specific histories, political economies, culture, and materials. This perspective trains you to read the built world as evidence: to see how territorial imperatives, spatial discipline, and governance organize daily life—and how people generate livelihood, community, resistance, and refusal within and against those arrangements.

For undergraduates across architecture, urban studies, history of art, geography, American studies, geography, public policy, and related fields, the course offers three decisive benefits. First, critical spatial literacy: the ability to interpret maps, plans, visual media, art, architecture and everyday urban form as instruments of power and as sites of contestation. Second, analytic range: connecting fine-grained local cases to global processes so you can build persuasive, well-grounded arguments about complex social worlds. Third, public-facing scholarship: clear writing and compelling visual argumentation that can inform civic debate, design decision-making, and policy work. In short, Space and Power is an essential graduate step for anyone who wants to analyze the present with precision and imagine more just spatial futures.

Course Objectives:

1. **Read space as evidence**—identify how racialized power is built into landscapes, neighborhoods, infrastructures, and borders.
2. **Map and visualize power**—use clear diagrams and mappings to reveal how the built environment organizes everyday life.
3. **Compare segregation logics**—analyze how spatial segregation works across cultures and historical periods, and explain the mechanisms behind it.
4. **Analyze borders**—built and unbuilt—explain how communities navigate, contest, and rework boundaries, partitions, and regimes of control.
5. **Synthesize multiple forms of evidence**—connect texts, images, and spatial traces to build arguments that are precise and well-supported.
6. **Communicate with impact**—write clearly, present persuasively, and craft strong visual arguments suited to public and academic audiences.
7. **Design and execute independent research**—select appropriate methods and represent complex data with accuracy and integrity.
8. **Produce a capstone-quality project**—deliver a polished research paper or a design-driven project with a rigorous written component.

Course Organization:
This course will be composed of three major parts:

1) **Weekly lecture (Tuesdays)** based on the assigned reading/listening materials,
2) **Weekly discussion (Thursdays)** with one student introducing the readings and the rest of the students engaging and asking questions;
3) **Workshop** related to research upon a student-chosen topic. which other students will provide mutual feedback in a workshop-like fashion;
4) **Final project** culminating the research upon the student-chosen topic which will be comprised of a major written portion and also a class presentation.

The course will be run as a reading and "looking" seminar for most of the semester, it will include a workshop in which students will present and critique one another's work in a supportive environment. The ultimate goal will be the production of a piece of writing that has the potential to be published. Alternatively, students may propose a design, mapping, or visual project, with a significant written component, such as an entry in a design competition, short film, photographic essay, mapping website, comic strip etc.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS
Attendance and participation are essential in this course. Evaluation accrues from cumulative work in class and assignments. For the final project, students may choose between a final research paper or a design or public intervention-based project with a significant written component.

Overview Requirements:

1. Weekly discussions: Students will lead discussion on the week's topic on Thursdays. Discussions will cover materials assigned for that week and should aim to spark discussion and debate amongst the class.
-Assigned Materials: Each week reading materials of approximately 30 pages per class—one to two articles or book chapter excepts—will be assigned to students to read closely. Additionally, short press pieces and audiovisual content will be assigned. Individually, students will make short oral reports of assigned readings on a rotating basis. Those not presenting are expected to prepare questions before the start of class. All readings will be uploaded to the Canvas website.
-Presenter Responsibilities: Each student will be expected to present one time throughout the semester. Strategies of leading discussion can vary: some students deliver formal presentations, while others ask questions to stimulate conversation. Presenting case studies for the class to investigate and analyze is strongly encouraged! Students will sign up for their discussion date on the second day of class.
Further Guidelines: Focus your presentation so that you are able to pose important questions and develop a conversation with the class. Tell us the most important insight that you gained from the text in question; identify points that you don't agree with. Incorporate images, videos, other texts and case studies to stimulate the debate. Presentations are not summations: I assume that you can recapitulate the author's argument.
-Audience Responsibilities: Students not leading discussion will be required to ask questions they have from assigned materials for that day. Audience members should bring these questions to class and be ready to discuss them.

2. Assignment: An assignment related to research on a student-chosen topic related to the course will be due at the end of the semester. For this, we will have an abstract workshop, during which students will present their work in a small group format to other students to give and receive feedback. These assignments—based on on-site observations, archival work, secondary literature, and interviews—will help students develop materials for their final project.
-Project Workshops: On **Tuesday 10/06 & Thursday 10/08** we will have a workshops to discuss your proposed projects with the class. Make sure to read each other's proposals and be ready to give feedback and ask questions. Prepare to present your idea in a couple of sentences.

3. Final Project & Presentation: A seminar paper of 8-15 pages in length, or a design-based project similar in scope, will be the final course requirement. All of the assignments and discussions throughout the semester should help inform students in completing this final project. Note, if you decide to do a design-based project you must receive my approval ahead of time.
-Final Presentation: At the end of the course, students will discuss their final project/findings in a 15 min presentation (conference style), supported by visual aids such as slides. Audience members will provide feedback to the student presenter.

Grading Distribution:
Your grade in the class will be based primarily on the work presented and submitted throughout the semester and the final paper and its presentation but will also take into account class participation and the quality of your feedback and questions.

- **Attendance and Participation 20%**
- **Reading presentations 20%**
- **Assignments and workshop presentation 20%**
- **Final presentation 10%**
- **Final Paper or Project 30%**

Course Schedule:

Week	Readings and Assignments
1	**Introductions** **Tuesday 09/01** First day of class, introductions, syllabus and themes overview. **Thursday 09/03** Mini-lecture and discussion 1. Carl H. Nightingale, "Introduction," in *Segregation, A Global History of Divided Cities* (Chicago and London: The University of Chicago Press, 2012): p.1-13. [PDF] 2. Shannon Stocking, "U-M research raises awareness of racially restrictive covenants in Ann Arbor housing" The Michigan Daily, January 26, 2021. [PDF]
2	**Race and the Built Environment** **Tuesday 09/08 & Thursday 09/10** [TEGRAN, KAIDEN, BENSON] 1. George Lipsitz, *How Racism Takes Place* (Temple University Press, 2011), "The White Spatial Imaginary" p. 25-50, and "The Black Spatial Imaginary," p.51-72. [PDF]

Week	Readings and Assignments
	2. Spend at least 20min exploring the *Mapping Inequality. Redlining in New Deal America* site, as well as the maps and descriptions for Detroit, MI.
3	**Architecture and Race** **Tuesday 09/15 & Thursday 09/17** [ADDISON, ASHLEY, REGINA] 1. Irene Cheng, Charles L. Davis II, Mabel O. Wilson "Introduction," in: *Race and Modern Architecture. A Critical History from the Enlightenment to the Present* (University of Pittsburgh Press, 2020), p. 3-14. [PDF] 2. Mauricio Tenorio Trillo, "Ch 7: Mexican Art and Architecture in Paris," in *Mexico at the World's Fairs* (Berkeley: University of California 1996), p. 96-125.
4	**Colonial Worlds and Imaginaries** **Tuesday 09/22 & Thursday 09/24** [HARRISON, HENRY, OLIVIA] 1. Barbara E. Mundy, *The Death of Aztec Tenochtitlan. The Life of* Mexico City (Austin: University of Texas Press, 2015), "Introduction" 1-24. [PDF] 2. Fernando Lara, "Abstraction is a Privilege", Platform Space, June 2021.
5	**Postcolonial Reckonings (Week online)** **Tuesday 09/29 & Thursday 10/01 24** [MANOOYEE, LUCILLE, ISHTIYAK] 1. Aimé Césaire, *Discourse on Colonialism* (Monthly Review Press, 2000, first published 1955), p. 35-46. 2. Valentina Rozas-Krause "Postcolonial Berlin: Reckoning with Traces of German Colonialism," in: Coslett, Daniel, *Neocolonialism and Built Heritage* (2020), 65-84. [PDF] 3. BBC, "Viewpoint: Why Germany's Namibia genocide apology is not enough" June 1, 2021. [PDF]
6	**Abstract-Project Workshop** **Tuesday 10/06 & Thursday 10/08** 1. Each student will present their project for the course and submit an abstract (300 words, title, 5 keywords, and at least one image) on Canvas on Monday 10/05 2. Please read all submissions and come prepared with questions and suggestions for your classmates
7	**Mappings** **Tuesday 10/13 & Thursday 10/15** [REN, ALVARO, CORNELIA] 1. Denis Cosgrove, ed., Mappings (London: Reaktion Books, 1999), introduction, pp. 2-23. 2. James Corner, "The Agency of Mapping: Speculation, Critique and Invention," in Denis Cosgrove, ed., Mappings, pp. 213-252.

Week	Readings and Assignments
8	**Ruins and Urban Nostalgia** **Tuesday 10/20** FALL STUDY BREAK, NO CLASS **Thursday 10/22** [RICH, JAYDN, LUPE] 1. Boym, Svetlana. *The Future of Nostalgia,* chapter 1. 2. Steinmetz, George, 2008 Harrowed Landscapes: White Ruingazers in Namibia and Detroit and the Cultivation of Memory. *Visual Studies* 23(3): 211-237.
9	**Publics and their Spaces** **Tuesday 10/27 & Thursday 10/29** [WAEL, TREVOR] 1. Michael Warner. "Publics and Counterpublics," *Public Culture (*2002), Vol 14, Issue 1, p. 49-90
10	**The Right to the City** **Tuesday 11/03 & Thursday 11/05** [BRIAN, LEAH, GABRIELLA] 2. Don Mitchell, *The Right To The City : Social Justice And The Fight For Public Space* (2014), Introduction and Chapter 1. 3.
11	**Gender and Space** **Tuesday 11/10 & Thursday 11/12** [ANYA, ANNALYSE] 1. Lauren Elkin, *Flaneuse: Women Walk the City in Paris, New York, Tokyo, Venice and London*, Introduction. 2. Valentina Rozas-Krause & Andrew M. Shanken eds, *Breaking the Bronze Ceiling*, Fordham UP 2024, Introduction.
12	**The Guilt Environment** **Tuesday 11/17 & Thursday 11/19** [MIA, KAYLI] 1. Susan Neiman, *Learning from the Germans* (New York : Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2019), prologue, 3-22. [PDF] 2. Carl H. Nightingale, "Segregation at the Extremes," in *Segregation, A Global History of Divided Cities* (Chicago and London: The University of Chicago Press, 2012): 333-358 [PDF]
13	**THANKSGIVING BREAK** **Tuesday 11/24 & Thursday 11/26** NO CLASS BOTH DAYS

Week	Readings and Assignments
14	**Final Presentations I** **Tuesday 12/01 & Thursday 12/03** The final two weeks will be devoted to presenting your final projects in 15-minute presentations. Naturally this is not your entire paper or project, but it should represent the totality of your argument in condensed form. This will be styled on the model of a conference paper.
15	**Final Presentations II** **Tuesday 12/08 & Thursday 12/10**
E	**FINAL PAPER** Submit your final paper or project on Canvas, **Tuesday 12/15 at noon.**

COURSE POLICIES AND IMPORTANT INFORMATION

Course Recordings:
Students are prohibited from recording/distributing any class activity without written permission from the instructor, except as necessary as part of approved accommodations for students with disabilities. Any approved recordings may only be used for the student's own private use.

Guidelines for Inclusive Classroom Interactions:

- **Share responsibility for including all voices in the conversation.** If you tend to have a lot to say, make sure you leave sufficient space to hear from others. If you tend to stay quiet in group discussions, challenge yourself to contribute so others can learn from you.
- **Listen respectfully.** Don't interrupt, turn to technology, or engage in private conversations while others are speaking. Use attentive, courteous body language. Comments that you make (whether asking for clarification, sharing critiques, or expanding on a point) should reflect that you have paid attention to the previous speakers' comments.
- **Be open to changing your perspectives based on what you learn from others.** Try to explore new ideas and possibilities. Think critically about the factors that have shaped your perspectives. Seriously consider points-of-view that differ from your current thinking.
- **Understand that we are bound to make mistakes in this space**, as anyone does when approaching complex tasks or learning new skills. Strive to see your mistakes and others' as valuable elements of the learning process.
- **Understand that your words have effects on others.** Speak with care. If you learn that something you've said was experienced as disrespectful or marginalizing, listen carefully and try to understand that perspective. Learn how you can do better in the future.
- **Take pair work or small group work seriously.** Remember that your peers' learning is partly dependent upon your engagement.

- **Understand that others will come to these discussions with different experiences from yours.** Be careful about assumptions and generalizations you make based only on your own experience. Be open to hearing and learning from other perspectives.
- **Make an effort to get to know other students.** Introduce yourself to the other students. Refer to classmates by name and make eye contact with other students.
- **Understand that there are different approaches to solving problems.** If you are uncertain about someone else's approach, ask a question to explore areas of uncertainty. Listen respectfully to how and why the approach could work.

Point of View:
(Adapted from Inclusive Syllabus Language)
The readings, class lecture, and my comments in class will suggest a particular point of view. This perspective is my own and does not have to be yours. I encourage you to disagree with the ideas in the readings and lectures as well as the perspectives of your colleagues in the course. A positive learning environment relies upon creating an atmosphere where diverse perspectives can be expressed, especially in a course that focuses on pressing and controversial social and political issues. Our conversations may not always be easy; we sometimes will make mistakes in our speaking and our listening; sometimes we will need patience or courage or imagination or any number of qualities in combination to engage our texts, our classmates, and our own ideas and experiences. Always we will need respect for others.

Each student is encouraged to take an active part in class discussions and activities. Honest and respectful dialogue is expected. Disagreement and challenging of ideas in a supportive and sensitive manner is encouraged. Hostility and disrespectful behavior is not acceptable. Just as we expect others to listen attentively to our own views, we must reciprocate and listen to others when they speak, especially when we disagree with them. However, in this class, our emphasis will be on engaging in the mutual exploration of issues as presented in the course readings as scholars rather than in defending points of view we have formed outside the classroom.

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities:
If you think you need an accommodation for a disability, please let me know at your earliest convenience. Some aspects of this course, the assignments, the in-class activities, and the way the course is usually taught may be modified to facilitate your participation and progress. As soon as you make me aware of your needs, we can work with the Services for Students with Disabilities (SSD) office to help us determine appropriate academic accommodations. SSD (734-763-3000; http://ssd.umich.edu) typically recommends accommodations through a Verified Individualized Services and Accommodations (VISA) form. Any information you provide is private and confidential and will be treated as such.

Mental Health and Wellbeing:
The University of Michigan is committed to advancing the mental health and wellbeing of its students. If you or someone you know is feeling overwhelmed, depressed, and/or in need of support, services are available. For help, contact Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS) at 734.764.8312 and caps.umich.edu during and after hours, on weekends and holidays, or through its counselors physically located in schools on both North and Central Campus. You may also consult University Health Service

(UHS) at 734.764.8320 and https://www.uhs.umich.edu/mentalhealthsvcs, or for alcohol or drug concerns, see https://www.uhs.umich.edu/aodresources.

Sexual Misconduct Policy:
Title IX prohibits discrimination on the basis of sex, which includes sexual misconduct — including harassment, domestic and dating violence, sexual assault, and stalking. We understand that sexual violence can undermine students' academic success and we encourage anyone dealing with sexual misconduct to talk to someone about their experience, so they can get the support they need. Confidential support and academic advocacy can be found with the Sexual Assault Prevention and Awareness Center (SAPAC) on their 24-hour crisis line, 734.936.3333 and at sapac.umich.edu. Alleged violations can be non-confidentially reported to the Office for Institutional Equity (OIE) at institutional.equity@umich.edu

Plagiarism:
We live in an age of sampling, quotation, and communal authorship. Despite this, plagiarism is treated seriously at the University of Michigan. It means taking credit for someone else's words, work, interpretations, or unique ideas without giving proper credit to the original creator—even if the site you use has no specific author (ie Wikipedia). *Any* instance of plagiarism in this course may result in a failing grade. For more information, see:
http://www.lib.umich.edu/handouts/plagiar.pdf
http://www.lsa.umich.edu/english/undergraduate/plagNote.asp
http://www.lsa.umich.edu/academicintegrity/

Artificial Intelligence:
Assignments and Final Papers should only use AI for basic inquires NOT FOR WRITING, and declare the AI model, prompts and results in the bibliography.

Modifications to syllabus:
I may modify any part of the syllabus during the course of the semester; students will be notified of any modifications in a timely manner.

Grading Standards:
A (100-94) reflects outstanding achievement in content and execution, exceeding expectations.
A- (93-89) reflects excellent work in content and execution.
B work (79-88) reflects high achievement in content and execution. Work meets or exceeds given requirements.
C work (69-78) barely fulfills given requirements.
D work (59-68) is less than satisfactory. Work minimally or incompletely fulfills given requirements.
E or F work fulfills few or none of the given requirements and represents a failing grade in the course.
I is given only for emergency, medical or COVID-19 related reasons.

Communications Information:
I welcome questions and I am always eager to discuss any thoughts you have related to material covered in class. Please visit me during office hours or make an appointment if you have anything you wish to discuss. Talking with me AFTER CLASS is best, as I am usually preparing before class.

Use of Email:
Please be sure that the registrar has your current email and that you are checking that email for communications from Canvas. I will reply to your emails as quickly as possible; sometimes it may take a day or two to get a response. The more clearly you can state your question the easier it will be for me to reply. I will not discuss issues relating to your performance in the course over email out of interests in security and because of the potential for misunderstanding. This includes requests to hand in a paper late. Please recognize that sending an e-mail stating that you are handing in a paper late or will not be attending class DOES NOT constitute or imply acceptance on my part; gaining permission means discussing the issue together and reaching a mutually-accommodating solution.

Attendance Policy:
Each student is expected to attend all class sessions. You are graded on your participation in seminar (10% of grade). Please do not come to class ill; if you provide me with a written medical excuse from your doctor, that will be taken into account when assessing attendance and final grades.

Make-up and Lateness Policy:
If you cannot attend class on the day an assignment is due or presentation is scheduled, you must contact me before at least 24 hours the class period you miss to discuss arrangements. No Exceptions!

In addition, all assignments must be submitted through Canvas on time—no exceptions. Your grade will be lowered by one increment per day late (A to A- for example) until the work is handed in. No late work will be accepted after one week. Exceptions may be made only in case of medical and personal emergencies supported by appropriate documentation. If there is a valid reason you are unable to submit work on the day it is due, you must consult with me TWO WEEKS BEFORE the deadline to make arrangements. PLEASE NOTE: Sending an email announcing you are handing something in late or missing a presentation is not acceptable; you need to talk to me.